

These issues are not confined to the realm of knowledge production; they carry ethical implications for scholars, policymakers, and journalists alike. When scholars narrowly put stock in actors' self-styled identities, the actors are likely getting precisely the result they wish to see, namely international audiences buying into their global marketing efforts. The Islamic State reaps benefits when audiences believe their behavior is driven by their ideology because such a response legitimates the ideology and reinforces their identity claims. In turn, such outcomes help the Islamic State with practical tasks such as recruitment and bolstering organizational cohesion. We can use political actors' identity assertions as empirical material but should refrain from using them as an analytical frame. Rather, striving toward ethical work means insisting on using our own theoretically-informed analytical approaches.

This conceptualization of actors' agency over identity formation and instrumentalization raises important questions: Why assume actors are strategic and instrumentalize identities? Do they not have sincere commitments to religious faiths? Certainly, individuals can have deep and genuine religious faiths, and such beliefs can and do shape behavior. Our approach is compatible with this understanding of religious faith. We ascribe strategic thinking because our subjects are by definition *political actors*—actors who aspire to alter political power dynamics in some way and seek to mobilize a base of supporters toward that end. Such actors *must* think about how to recruit, expand their realm of control, and make progress toward the attainment of objectives. To succeed, they must be calculating and strategic about the use of various resources at their disposal—including identity formulation and utilization.

Moving Forward

Identitized issues, be they “religious” conflicts or threats from “religious” actors, should be better understood once observers free themselves of the very identities through which the actors themselves would have us understand their behavior. Multi-identitizing analysis does not mean disregarding actors' identities; identities are important precisely because they matter to individuals and groups and hence can play powerful political roles. Rather, when a political actor frames an issue as being *about* a (religious or other) identity, we ought to think about the fuller inventory of identities available to the actor as well as consider why and for what ends the actor is emphasizing the particular identity over others. Given the actor's goals and circumstances, what are their political motives? “*Why, and what else?*” might be a refrain that can help bring greater clarity to studies of identity. This way of thinking provides a window into actors' strategic thinking and places self-styled identities alongside other social, economic, and political factors that shape outcomes. The analyst, not the actor's pronouncements, should then determine what role an identity has on the actor's behavior.

Religion, Ideology, Institutions, and Patterns of Violence

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Scholars of armed organizations with ideologies that claim to be based on religion have increasingly documented micro-level variation in the attitudes and conduct of individual members of the organization who sometimes but do not always comply with the organization's ideology, i.e., its official interpretation of religion (Gutiérrez Sanín and Wood 2014; Leader Maynard 2019). It is now well-established that ideology—as expressed through an organization's official policies and doctrines—is a causal factor in the violence wielded by members of armed organizations, although scholars disagree about its importance relative to other factors

including economic incentives (Weinstein 2006), changes in the relative military power of competing organizations leading to “side-switching” (Christia 2012), and territorial control (Kalyvas 2006). However, there is more to be learned about how and why individual members of an organization vary in their level of commitment to the ideology, whether religious or secular, and the role that commitment plays in the divergence between violence prescribed as policy and that observed on the ground.

In our study on the Islamic State’s pattern of sexual violence (Revin and Wood 2021), we documented how the organization’s ideology—based on a selective and extreme interpretation of Islam—authorized the targeting of particular social groups with specific forms of sexual violence, but effectively prohibited the targeting of other groups with those specific forms. However, we also found that the pattern of violence was more diverse than those policies predicts: Unauthorized but tolerated “practices” of violence also occurred. In this essay, we briefly review our findings and discuss fruitful avenues for further research.

After showing that extant theories of violence do not fully explain the Islamic State’s observed pattern of violence, we argue that its pattern of violence is better explained by ideology. By *ideology*, we mean “a more or less systematic set of ideas that includes the identification of a referent group (a class, ethnic, or other social group), an enunciation of the grievances or challenges that the group confronts, the identification of objectives on behalf of that group (political change—or defense against its threat), and a (perhaps vaguely defined) program of action” (Gutiérrez Sanín and Wood 2014: 215). Ideology, to varying extent, prescribes policies that order or authorize particular forms of violence against specific social groups (i.e., particular sub-patterns of violence) and proscribes other sub-patterns. It also prescribes—again, to varying extent—institutions to produce violence it deems legitimate, to regulate the conditions under which authorized violence occurs, and to punish prohibited sub-patterns of violence.

We find that the organization adopted policies that authorized certain forms of sexual violence, including sexual slavery and child marriage, against distinct social groups. However, some sub-patterns of violence were “practices,” namely, *violence that is neither ordered nor authorized but nonetheless tolerated by commanders* (Wood 2018), e.g., gang rape of Yazidi women (which violated its policy requiring exclusive ownership of and sexual access to slaves) and forced marriage of Sunni Muslim women (which violated its policy requiring that marriage be consensual).

We also found evidence that the Islamic State’s pattern of violence varied across non-contiguous “provinces” in Afghanistan, Nigeria, and other contexts where pre-existing organizations (Boko Haram in Nigeria and the Taliban in Afghanistan) pledged allegiance to the Islamic State. We suggest that their pre-existing organizational policies and practices, along with local cultural traditions, hindered the Islamic State’s efforts to enforce compliance with its ideology. Forced marriage of Sunni women was a frequent occurrence in the Islamic State’s affiliate in Afghanistan, e.g., even though it was prohibited by the Islamic State’s official ideology and occurred only occasionally as a practice in its core territory in Iraq and Syria.

Our article and other previous research have suggested that peer socialization may help to explain discrepancies between official policy and observed patterns of violence. Members of an armed organization are socialized *vertically* from the top down (to varying degrees) as well as *horizontally* through peer influence (Checkel 2017). Whether from above or through peers, socialization may reinforce official policies or undermine them (Wood and Toppelberg 2017). Socialization from above may reinforce official policy through education, training, and discipline as well as the enforcement of traditions, concepts, rituals, and other social processes. Top-down socialization by particular officers may, on the other hand, undermine official policies through unauthorized and perhaps illegal behavior and discourse,

which may explain practices of violence by particular units that deviate from policy. Horizontal socialization in the form of rituals, traditions, and other processes between peers may similarly undermine official policies by reinforcing prohibited forms of violence, which if tolerated become sustained practices (Wood and Toppelberg 2017). Horizontal socialization into formal organizational norms and rules is also possible in highly cohesive and deeply socializing organizations.

One of the best-documented examples of sexual violence as a practice is the pattern of frequent sexual assault of both female and male members of the US military by their colleagues (almost always male; Wood and Toppelberg 2017). That it is driven primarily by horizontal social dynamics is evident in the fraction of rapes that are carried out by multiple perpetrators (much higher than among civilians) and in the frequent retaliation for reporting sexual assault not only by the perpetrator but by the victim's peers and unit leaders. No one claims that such intra-force violence is organizational policy, yet it has persisted despite two decades of supposed "zero tolerance."

An important methodological challenge to research on practices is that they are observed primarily through the behavior or communications of individual members, in contrast to policies, which are formally expressed in texts or other communications that are relatively easy for researchers to access and interpret. Nonetheless, scholars can find evidence of practices through interviews with current or former members of an armed organization, or with individuals who though not members of the organization could observe the conduct of its members (e.g., family members or civilians living in areas controlled by the organizations), or—in cases where it is not possible to interview members of an organization—by collecting statements that individuals make on social media, in diaries or other archival records, or during judicial investigations.

Below we suggest some questions for future research on the relationship between religious ideologies, ideologies more generally, and both policies and practices of violence.

To what extent does our argument about religious ideology prescribing institutions and policies of violence account for patterns by other armed organizations that draw on religious ideology to motivate and legitimate armed conflict, including other Salafi-jihadist organizations?

Does our argument generalize to ideologies drawing on different religious traditions? Extending our theoretical framework to the study of patterns of violence by armed organizations with other religious ideologies would help to address a problematic double standard identified by Kanchan Chandra in this Forum in which Islamist organizations are often singled out as if they are particularly prone to violence while overlooking many examples of extreme violence by organizations that claim to be motivated by other religions. For example, the Ku Klux Klan is rarely referred to as a Christian organization despite its extensive use of biblical verses, Christian symbols (most notably the burning cross), and churches to promote its ideology. Earlier Christian white nationalist movements cited biblical justifications for enslaving and lynching Black Americans (Gorski and Perry 2022, 54; Louise Wood 2011, 48). These preliminary observations suggest, consistent with our theory, that the patterns of violence of Christian white nationalist movements are shaped by their ideologies.

The finding that different religious ideologies are associated with different patterns of violence raises a related question: Do differences in political ideology account for differences in patterns of violence across leftist insurgencies? In Latin America, Sendero Luminoso engaged in a much wider repertoire, targeting, and higher frequency of violence against civilians than did the Frente Farabundo Martí de Liberación Nacional in El Salvador, for example. To what extent is the difference accounted for by differences in ideology? By peer dynamics including social rituals as well as ideology?

Another set of questions concerns the relationship between religion and ideology. Does treating religion as merely one form of ideology among others (e.g., political or philosophical ideologies) neglect important aspects of the lived experience of combatants that involve faith practices and rituals? Both secular and religious armed organizations may have ideologies aimed at the realization of a higher good, and corresponding institutions designed to promote combatants’ belief in that good. How precisely do religious beliefs and rituals differ from the secular beliefs and rituals in ideological armed organizations that do not subscribe to a particular religion? From those in more professional state militaries, including drilling and hazing?

Finally, what happens when different commanders have different interpretations of the organization’s policies? Local commanders often encounter situations not covered or even anticipated by official policies, which may lead them to adapt existing policies or develop new policies based on their individual interpretation of the underlying ideology. To what extent does variation across local commanders’ interpretation of official ideology and policies account for variation in patterns of violence *within* armed organizations? To what extent does that variation reflect socialization that undermines official policy (rather than a good-faith interpretation)?

We hope these questions raised by our theoretical framework will be taken up by other scholars studying armed organizations with different religious ideologies as well as those with secular ideologies and in different historical and regional contexts to build generalizable knowledge across different categories—such as Salafi-jihadist groups—that may not be as *sui generis* as they are often assumed.

Religious Fieldwork for International Relations Scholars

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Social scientists are, by and large, a fairly non-religious bunch, at least in the United States. Surveys conducted by the Carnegie Commission on Higher Education in the 1960s, 70s, and 80s show declining religiosity among faculty in the United States. These surveys have not been updated, but the latest, in 1984, shows that even then, only 6% of political scientists were “deeply religious” while 54% were indifferent or opposed to religion.⁸ It is safe to say that religiosity of social science faculty has continued to decline. This contrasts with remarkable levels of religiosity among the American public; some 50% of Americans reported that religion was “very important” to them in a 2014 Pew survey.⁹

The inexperience of many social scientists with religion may detrimentally affect how we study it. We may discount religion as a cause of political action because we ourselves are not as likely to find it motivating. When we do acknowledge its force, we sometimes adopt simplistic understandings of religious identity, discuss canonical texts without considering varied interpretations, and give too much attention to religious ideology and too little to religious practices.

As a remedy, scholars could prioritize religious fieldwork: Going to, entering, and observing the religious spaces they study and the people who inhabit them. This may entail traditional fieldwork, but the increasing importance of virtual religious practice means that scholars can also gain experience by attending online religious services and perusing websites. Social scientists who increase their intuitive understanding of religion by observing (and perhaps practicing) will produce better scholarship about religion because they better appreciate the motivations and experiences of religious people. This is not to say that they will take the statements of religious subjects at face value—experience can also be instructive about when

⁸See https://www.thearda.com/Archive/Files/Downloads/NSHEF84_DL2.asp (accessed March 24, 2023); Wald and Wilcox (2006, 526).

⁹See https://www.thearda.com/Archive/Files/Codebooks/RELLAND14_CB.asp, question 77 Q.F2 (accessed March 24, 2023).